
NEWS

Santa Clara County Leaders Cut Out Flock Safety in New Surveillance Policy

Santa Clara County supervisors amended their own policies to restrict Flock Safety license plate cameras in three South Bay cities.

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By Joseph Geha









An automated license plate reader is seen mounted on a pole on June 13, 2024, in San Francisco, California. Santa Clara County Supervisors amended their own policies to restrict Flock Safety license plate cameras in three South Bay cities. *(Justin Sulli*

Santa Clara County leaders are distancing themselves from automated license plate reader company Flock Safety due to growing concerns about the use of its data for immigration enforcement. A split decision on Tuesday afternoon by the Board of Supervisors to effectively cut ties with Flock brings the county in league with dozens of other local governments that have canceled or paused the technology. The severings follow media reports that federal agencies like Customs and Border Protection and Immigration and Customs Enforcement were able to access data from vast local Flock cameras.

“I do not believe the County of Santa Clara should be doing business with Flock,” District 2 Supervisor Betty Duong said at a press conference on Tuesday morning.

“Flock is a problematic company, and their reported conduct and sharing of private data is incompatible with our county’s values, my personal values and the values that I promised the voters





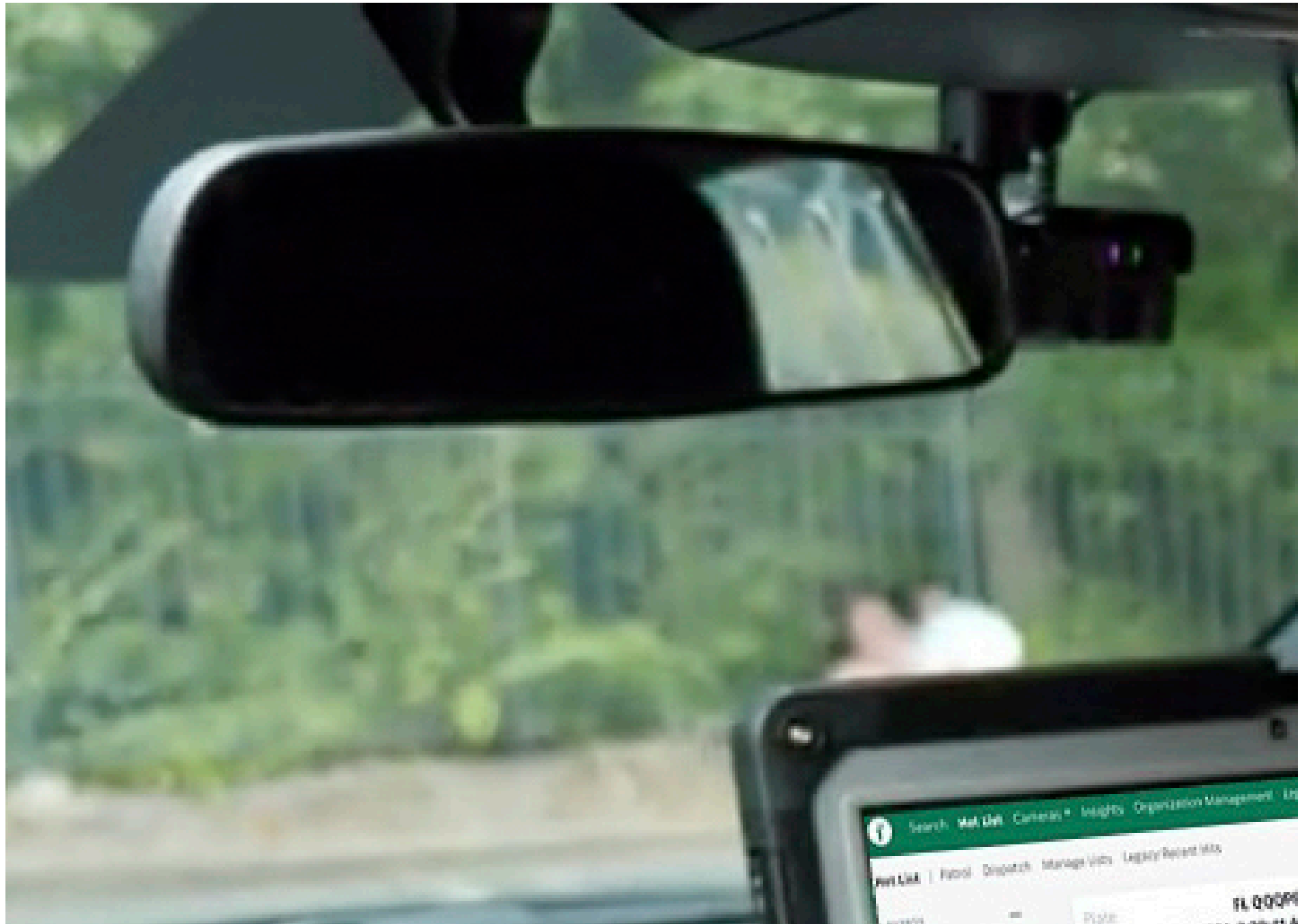


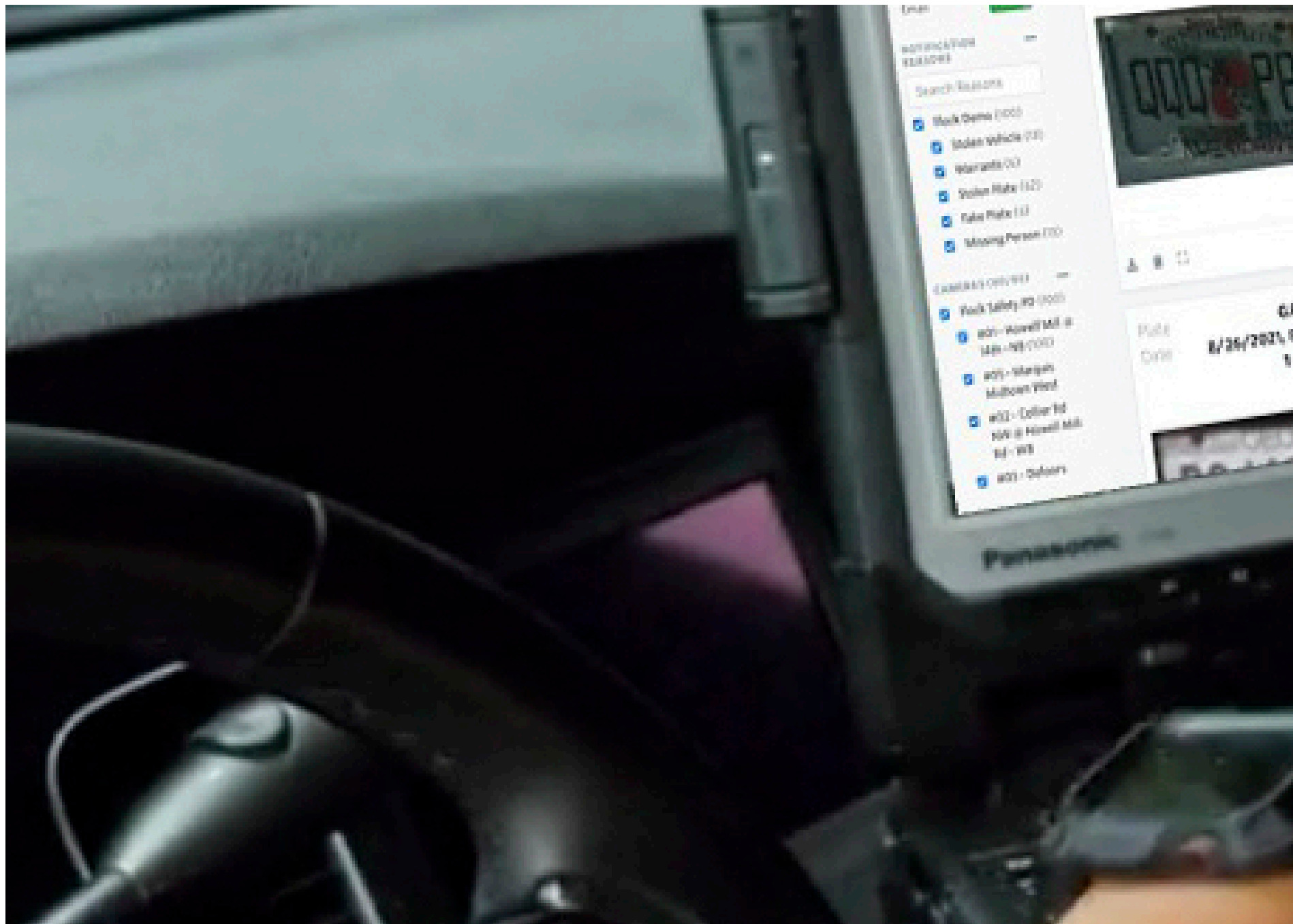
Automated License Plate Readers (ALPRs) are seen at the intersection of Washington and La Cienega boulevards on Thursday, Nov. 20, 2025, in Culver City, California. (Kayla Bartkowski / Los Angeles Times via Getty Images)

While there are many license plate reader vendors, Flock has become one of the largest suppliers, with tens of thousands of cameras in more than 5,000 cities and counties around the nation. The board voted 3-2 in favor of amending its own policies to effectively render Flock cameras useless in Cupertino and Saratoga, two South Bay cities that currently contract with the Santa Clara County Sheriff's Office. The board's decision also applies to Los Altos Hills, though that small town's leadership decided to terminate its contract with Flock last month. Because the sheriff's office runs law enforcement for those three places, it also oversees the license plate cameras that those cities and towns use. All three have relied on Atlanta-based Flock. Under the newly updated county "Surveillance Use Policy" adopted by the board, the sheriff's office will no longer access or use any data sourced from a Flock camera. "Effective immediately, the sheriff's office and the staff cannot operate, manage or touch the cameras, the data, transmission, anything from ALPRs that are operated by Flock, vendored by Flock," the policy states. While the county doesn't have the authority to force those cities to end their Flock contracts, the change in policy appears to make the images and data being logged by those cameras moot, as

Cupertino City Manager Tina Kapoor confirmed Tuesday that the city's Flock contract is active.

"We will be evaluating the agreement based on the county's decision and other considerations at the moment, such as our upcoming law enforcement contract with the county and the budget, Duong noted that if Cupertino or Saratoga were to find new vendors for license plate readers, the sheriff's office would likely be able to quickly resume oversight and operation of that technology. However, some county leaders raised broader concerns about the technology of ALPRs, which, in Flock's case, record not only a car's license plate, but also its make and model, color and description. Supervisor Susan Ellenberg voted against the change in policy on Tuesday because she feels license plate readers in general represent an "excessive invasion of privacy," and that those concerns. "Flock is particularly problematic. But I differ from my colleagues in that I don't believe they are an outlying bad actor and alternatives are not necessarily any safer," Ellenberg said during the discussion. "I am really existentially troubled by the expansion of the surveillance state and its contribution to the erosion of democracy, civil liberties and other protections that actually create safer communities." "Alleviating poverty and ensuring stable housing, sufficient nutrition, access to health care and education, clean and well-lit streets, of course, create more safety than surveillance cameras, even







Law enforcement agencies are deploying vehicle-tracking networks with settings that some advocates say can make local data nationally searchable. *(Courtesy of Flock Safety)*

Nick Hidalgo, a senior staff attorney with the ACLU of Northern California, said the county's move was encouraging but that it does not go far enough.

"There is no guarantee that rival ALPR vendors will do better," he said. "These companies market their systems as easy to share with other law enforcement agencies — sharing is by design, ar

A spokesperson for Flock Safety, Paris Lewbel, said in an emailed statement that the company "is proud of the impact our technology has had in helping solve crimes and locate missing people

Locally, other cities have also taken steps to back away from Flock.

Mountain View's City Council voted unanimously to [end a contract and terminate](#) automatic license plate readers on Tuesday.

Councilmember Ellen Kamei said the city learned a lesson.

"Acknowledging a situation, acting quickly and communicating openly reflects integrity and public service," she said. "We've talked about how our city is known as a community for all, and be

Santa Cruz became the first city in California to [sever ties with Flock](#) in January, following similar data-sharing problems, which violate longstanding state laws against sharing ALPR data wit

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According to NPR, at least 30 localities have either deactivated their Flock cameras or canceled their contracts since the beginning of 2025, with many of the changes happening this year.

The Trump administration's crackdown on illegal immigration has heightened awareness and concern around such technologies, but privacy and civil liberties advocates have long pushed back.

A group of civil-liberties and immigrant-support organizations [sued San José](#) over what they allege is the city's "deeply invasive" mass surveillance network of hundreds of Flock cameras.

The city, the largest in the Bay Area, holds onto all ALPR data for a year, well beyond the 30-day default of Flock, whether a car is implicated in a crime or not.

The county's new policy will also require immediate reporting to the board if any unauthorized ALPR data under county control is shared with the federal government. It will also require audi

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